Houseplant Care Handbook

Watering

Most houseplants want the top few centimetres of soil to dry out between waterings. Pushing a finger into the pot is a better guide than a calendar, because light, temperature and pot size all change how fast soil dries.

Overwatering is the most common way houseplants die. Roots sitting in wet soil cannot take up oxygen, so they rot, and a plant with rotten roots wilts exactly like a plant that needs water.

Light

Bright indirect light suits most foliage plants. A south-facing window can scorch thin leaves in summer, while a north-facing room may be too dim for anything except the most shade-tolerant species.

Repotting

Repot when roots circle the bottom of the pot or water runs straight through. Move up only one pot size at a time; a much larger pot holds water the roots cannot reach, which brings back the overwatering problem.

Check the undersides of leaves for fungus gnats, mealybugs and spider mites. Isolating a new plant for two weeks keeps a hitchhiking pest from spreading to the rest of the collection.